

Japan's Great Peace

In the 17th century, Japan shut the door to the outside world. Anybody venturing abroad and daring to return would be executed. For the next 250 years a newly unified Japan was steered along a path of *sakoku*, or national seclusion, and developed its economy and a unique cultural identity.

Imagine a 17th-century city of towering stone walls, long wooden parapets, huge gatehouses, and massive moats, all sprawling out from the largest castle in the world. This bustling town-port with artisans, traders, and laborers is Edo (present-day Tokyo), a city twice the size of the largest cities in Europe at the time, such as London and Paris. Its busy thoroughfares were filled with people from different classes, all of whom were beneficiaries of a new period known as

the “Great Peace” or Edo Period. Early-modern Japan was experiencing a period of previously unknown calm that was to last over 250 years.

Shogun authority

Under the newly installed shogun (see pp.168–69) ruler Tokugawa Ieyasu, Edo became the military capital of Japan. The emperor and his court—though revered—were consigned to ceremonial stature at Kyoto, which was Japan’s capital at that time. The Imperial court, powerless but prestigious, conferred the title shogun and Ieyasu manipulated this “support” to his advantage. But the key players in the pacification of Japan were the

daimyo (see pp.168–69), regional leaders who controlled the provinces. The shogun, while exercising control from Edo, had to work with these local

magnates, in order to maintain power in distant provinces that were difficult to reach. It was an uneasy alliance veering between accommodation and manipulation: the *daimyo* had to obey the shogun on important policies, and their wives and children had to live in Edo periodically to act as collateral, but they exercised a good deal of freedom

and control in their local areas. They were allowed to demand physical labor and duties from local villagers, including taxes and rent.

“[Edo] is on most days **more crowded than** a public street in any of the most populous towns of **Europe.**”

DUTCH TRADER ENGELBERT KASMPFERER, 1621

Edo, largest town

This print by the Japanese artist Ando Hiroshige reveals an 18th-century view of Edo, which was the one of the largest cities in the world throughout the 18th century. Today the Japanese view Edo, upon which Tokyo grew, as the home of their traditional culture, and people born in Tokyo are still known as *Edo-ko*, or children of Edo.

The great change

Under the shogunate, Japanese society was put through a largely successful experiment of “social engineering.” The population was labeled as to whether they were samurai, farmers, craftsmen, or merchants. At the apex of the system were the warrior class, the samurai, who were the only individuals allowed to carry weapons. As a class, samurai were controlled by the military leaders and worked as government officials, guards, policemen, or for local authorities, serving either the shogun or one of the local *daimyo*.

The great change in Japanese society was the elevation of farmers—who made up 80 percent of the population, and whose labor was critical to the economy—to the second rank of society. Although at the mercy of the *daimyo* and samurai, the peasant farmers enjoyed a high degree of village autonomy. They elected leaders and formed collective assemblies that decided on local issues. They paid taxes (in rice) as a village unit and were granted individual rights to cultivate the land registered to them. In

BEFORE

Before the Edo period, Japan was a politically divided and unstable country.

CIVIL WAR

From the 12th to the late 16th centuries, Japan experienced intermittent civil war << 168–69.

THE COMING OF PEACE

The battle of **Sekigahara** was the last great field battle between two Japanese armies. The victor, Tokugawa Ieyasu, the son of a *daimyo* (warlord) took the title of **shogun** (military dictator).

